BOOKS ▶

SEEKING Sacred Ground

NAMITA DEVIDAYAL's *new book captures her passage from worldly scepticism to spiritual clarity through the teachings of Vedanta*

TANGERINE
How to Read the Upanishads Without Giving Up Coffee
By Namita Devidayal
WESTLAND
₹**599; 224** pages



Tangerine begins as the story of a liberal, English-speaking journalist who stayed at a distance from organised religion. The very title of the book tells us this—the owning of the colour saffron under the alternative 'tangerine'; the promise to people like her that this journey is not something weird and you don't have to give up coffee or whatever you fear giving up! But Namita Devidayal is also someone nourished by her cultural roots—mythologies where plants and animals take centrestage, and the philosophical wisdom of mother figures and teachers. Later in the story, when she unapologetically makes a shrine for herself, she does so as a full "United Nations of benevolence" with images of Shiva, Durga, Christ, Zarathustra, Guru Nanak... and her god of music, Alladiya Khan.

Like innumerable seekers before her, exhausted by suffering, unable to find help in the usual resources, Namita, too, turns to the spiritual in the hope of something larger, transcendent and lasting—and finds it. This is the enriching story of how she takes her leap of faith into studying Vedanta, the tradition of spiritual inquiry contained in the Upanishads, the Gita, and the Brahma Sutras. She regularly goes to an ashram in Rishikesh and learns from teachers who are erstwhile cosmopolitan professionals. She negotiates how to make her loved ones easy with these changes even as



ESSENTIAL INDIA EDITIONS
Aleph Book Company
₹**399** each

BOOKS ▶

Compulsory Reading

Aleph Book Company's Essential India editions is a wide-ranging series on some of the iconic aspects of India

It's not yet another explainer series, clarifies David Davidar, co-founder, Aleph Book Company, of *Essential India Editions*, a series of compact volumes that stand out—apart from the attractive covers—for their star-studded cast of writers. "The books in the series are not textbooks or simple explanations of this or that. They are original explorations of what it means to be Indian by examining aspects of India that are found nowhere else," says Davidar.

Five books in the series are already out: *Our Living Constitution* by Shashi Tharoor; *Language of the Immortals* (a concise history of Sanskrit by G.N. Devy); *Dance of Freedom* (on Bharata Natyam by Leela Samson); *The Mysterious World of Tigers* by Valmik Thapar; and *Song of India* (about the national anthem,

The series of compact volumes stand out, **apart from the attractive covers,** for the star-studded cast of writers. Around 50 are planned